

Attention

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Abstract

Attention is not detection. Detection finds patterns in data. Attention is a capacity earned through failure to notice what matters. The two produce similar outputs on easy problems. They diverge at the wall.

A surgeon notices something wrong before she can name it. Not because she processed more data. Because her attention has been shaped by encounters that taught her what to look for by first failing to see it.

This is attention in the strong sense: a trained capacity to perceive that has been earned through missed things.

AI has attention in the weak sense. It weights inputs. It learns which patterns predict which outputs. This is detection. Detection is not wrong. Detection is what it is.

The difference appears at the edge.

The surgeon in the new case. The mathematician at the novel obstacle. The reader encountering a sentence that says something no sentence has said before.

Weak attention fails at the edge. Strong attention is what the edge requires.

Polanyi's skilled reader does not read by decoding. She attends to meaning. The difference is the object. Decoding takes symbols as input. Attending takes meaning as input.

Meaning is not in the signal. It is what the signal points to. To attend to meaning requires knowing what is pointed at. That knowledge is not extractable from the signal. It requires having been somewhere.

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Having been somewhere is the condition.

The mathematician who has failed at the wall has been somewhere that the proof does not record. The proof records what was found. It does not record the failure that taught the finder what to look for.

The attention that found the proof is not in the proof. It is in the mathematician. It cannot be transferred. It can only be rebuilt, slowly, through encounter.

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This is why reading every paper does not give you the attention of the author. It gives you the output of their attention.

Output is not attention. It is what attention found. Finding the same output again is not the same capacity.

The map records the territory. The explorer knows the territory. The distinction is not metaphorical. It is the difference between a record and a capacity.

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The question is not whether AI can detect. It can. The question is whether it can attend.

Attend in the strong sense: perceive what matters in a case where the patterns do not decide, where something is at stake that cannot be pre-specified, where failure is the teacher and the teaching takes time.

That question is not settled by outputs. It is settled by what happens at the edge.

References

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